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SOCIAL PSYCHOLOGICAL ANALYSIS: FACTORS CONTRIBUTING TO CANCEL CULTURE

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Abstract – The prevalence of cancel culture in today's society has captured the attention of the general public, the media, and even researchers. The current paper describes three relatively recent (and, arguably, controversial) examples of cancel culture and then identifies and describes three group-related social psychological factors—social contagion, group polarization, groupthink—that may contribute to cancel culture via social media. Using the empirical social psychological literature, these group-related factors are defined and discussed in the context of cancel culture. By describing and applying three group-related social psychological factors, the paper reveals how social psychological science can help explain people's tendency to banish or "cancel" individuals accused of violating moral norms.

Keywords: assessing creativity, torrance, drawings

In 2021, singer-songwriter and film director—Sia—debuted the movie *Music* which cast a neurotypical actress in the role of a nonverbal autistic teenager. A mass of viewers—over 55,000—signed a petition to have the film officially condemned by the industry, in hopes of removing its two Golden Globe nominations (Sparks, 2021). The action taken by viewers was, in large part, because Sia failed to cast a neurodivergent individual in the role of the nonverbal autistic teenager, thereby excluding disabled and neurodiverse actors from their own narratives.

In 2022, a respected and accomplished professor of organic chemistry—Dr. Maitland Jones Jr—was denied a contract at New York University, because a swath of students signed a petition against him (Saul, 2022). The students, who used a GroupMe chat to unite their frustrations about the organic chemistry course, blamed Dr. Jones for their poor test scores, claiming his expectations were unreasonable and unachievable. Although Dr. Jones defended his standards, his contract was nevertheless terminated.

Finally, in early 2023, newspapers across the nation—including well-renowned and highly read papers such as The Boston Globe, The Washington Post, and The Los Angeles Times—stopped printing the *Dilbert* comic strip because the creator—Scott Adams—made denigrating comments about Black people. Specifically, as part of a YouTube livestream, Mr. Adams described Black people as "a hate group" and espoused the belief that it "makes no sense to help Black Americans if you're White." Mr. Adams feigned ignorance to the racist nature of his remarks and Tweeted "An obvious question for those who canceled me is do they disagree with my point. So far I have not seen it. I only see disagreement with my use of hyperbole" (Adams, 2023).

The examples reported previously demonstrate the idea of cancel culture, which is broadly defined as strategies to socially isolate and ostracize people accused of offensive comments or actions (Norris, 2023). Specifically, cancel culture reflects the public shaming of individuals for their unacceptable comments or actions in hopes that they experience personal and/or professional consequences (Tandoc et al., 2022). Cancel culture's recent proliferation may be due, in large part, to the rapid transmission of information via social media, which makes cancel culture feel distinctive and controversial. In fact, Vogels et al. from the Pew Research Center (2021) recently revealed that 58% of U.S. adults believe that calling attention to individuals' words or deeds on social media is an effective method for holding them accountable, whereas 38% believe that such action has the capacity to punish people unnecessarily. Given disparate perceptions of the effectiveness of cancel culture online, it is important to understand the conditions that may foster or exacerbate its use. The current paper uses the empirical social psychological

literature to identify and explain three group-related factors (i.e., social contagion, group polarization, groupthink) that may contribute to the proliferation of cancel culture via social media.

Social Contagion

The first social psychological phenomenon that may contribute to cancel culture is social contagion. According to the American Psychology Association (2023), social contagion is defined as the spread of attitudes, emotions, and behaviors across groups of people. Arguably, cancel culture operates and persists through the mechanism of social contagion, which is exacerbated via social media. In fact, Tandoc et al. (2022) argue that the anonymity often provided to social media users allows them to easily participate in cancel culture—spreading ideas—without social barriers. Relatedly, Brady et al. (2020) argue that social contagion of ideas is magnified on social media due to the rapid spread of inherently social and emotional content. Thus, the spread of ideas on social media platforms can help explain how social contagion contributes to cancel culture.

Social contagion often occurs when information is rich with moral and emotional language—something common in arguments associated with cancel culture. For example, Barrios-O'Neill (2021) investigated the role of emotional language in the social contagion of messages from leading non-governmental organizations on Twitter. In the study, Barrios-O'Neill examined exactly 1000 of the most recent Twitter posts from each of ten environmental agencies working to educate the public about threats to biodiversity, such as overexploitation and climate change. The results revealed that the use of negative emotional language in these posts significantly boosted social contagion (e.g., #stopkillingsharks; Barrios-O'Neill, 2021), demonstrating how information that is rich with emotional content can spread.
In an additional study examining the role of moral emotions in the spread of ideas on social media, Brady et al. (2017) analyzed 563,312 tweets (on the social media platform Twitter) reflecting three polarizing political and moral topics: gun control, climate change, and same-sex marriage. Results revealed that the use of moral-emotional words in tweets increased the spread of the words by approximately 20% (Brady et al.). Such results demonstrate that the use of moral-emotional language in social media posts can increase the social contagion of ideas online.

The research by Barrios-O'Neill (2021) and Brady et al. (2017) are excellent examples of how ideas conveyed online using moral and emotional language, especially negative emotional language, contributes to the spread of those ideas (i.e., social contagion). Because cancel culture tends to reflect topics of moral significance, such as racism, sexual violence, ableism, and sexism, this evidence explains how such information is rapidly propagated and perpetuated online.

Group Polarization

Group polarization reflects the idea that, in groups, individuals tend to report more extreme opinions, responses, or decisions than if they reported their opinions, responses, or decisions individually (Myers & Lamm, 1976). That is, on average, when individuals are in groups of like-minded others, they tend to report more polarized attitudes—such as a shift to more extreme attitudes—than when not in groups. Whyte (1989) explains that group polarization occurs because groups of like-minded people experience pressure to maintain uniformity in their ideas and have little need to challenge or critically examine information for which everyone already agrees. Consequently, extreme versions of ideas can emerge and be sustained.

Arguably, group polarization can flourish on social networking sites just as it does for groups that form offline or in person. In a demonstration of group polarization online, Strandberg et al. (2019) assigned like-minded individuals to in-person or online discussion groups about the status of the Swedish language in Finland (a national language spoken by only 5.4% of the population). Results revealed that group polarization was just as likely to occur in free discussions online as it was for free discussions in person. Such results demonstrate how group polarization occurs in online discussions with like-minded individuals and, therefore, may have implications for the proliferation of cancel culture online.

Interestingly, some researchers have argued that social media promotes and favors polarizing spaces thus decreasing users' ability to access diverse content (Iandoli et al., 2021). Specifically, Iandoli et al. (2021) conducted a systematic review of the literature, which included summarizing results from 121 research papers, examining the presence of group polarization on social media and other online discussion-based platforms. Results of the systematic review revealed various mechanisms promoting group polarization online. For example, social media was thought to create environments where users consume and share information that reinforces their opinions. Additionally, Iandoli et al.'s review revealed that social media allows—oftentimes encourages—individuals to find socially similar others, which can promote the creation of groups that possess homogeneous beliefs. After reviewing the literature, Iandoli et al. boldly stated that communications via social media can intentionally contribute to group polarization (Iandoli et al., 2020). If social media supports the

emergence of polarizing echo-chambers that do, in fact, reduce users' exposure to diverse information, such lack of information diversity may promote cancel culture. Specifically, group polarization may be one mechanism whereby individuals experience social pressure—from like-minded individuals—to ostracize targets accused of offensive words or deeds. Because cancel culture is often centered on moral or ethical topics, it is understandable how the polarization of individuals' attitudes can heighten their moral convictions and fuel their desire to see violators punished.

Groupthink (and the Illusion of Morality)

A third social psychological phenomenon that may contribute to cancel culture is groupthink. Groupthink is described as a way of thinking whereby members of a cohesive group strive to form united beliefs at the expense of exploring alternative ideas (Janis, 1982). Although groupthink emerges due to a variety of factors, understanding the function of group illusions, specifically that of the illusion of morality, is particularly relevant to cancel culture.

The illusion of morality describes the idea that individuals experience certainty in their moral convictions on various issues (Forsyth, 2020). Because cancel culture often involves seeking consequences (e.g., financial and/or social) for violators of moral norms, individuals engaged in canceling a violator of a moral norm may experience heightened certainty—experience an illusion of their morality—in the rightness of their moral perspective. In fact, Stern (2016) argues that individuals experience a desire to be in groups that feel empowered by and superior in their moral convictions (i.e., righteousness indignation). Such an illusion of morality may contribute to cancel culture by creating an illusion of moral superiority that is derived from groupthink.

In a demonstration of the illusion of morality contributing to groupthink, Forysth (2020) analyzed the media posts from groups of individuals highly resistant to quarantining—termed anti-quarantine groups—during the COVID-19 pandemic. Forysth's analysis revealed that anti-quarantine groups may have believed that their arguments were morally superior to opposing arguments. Specifically, anti-quarantine groups asserted moral claims associated with people's rights to engage in behaviors such as traveling freely, which were violated by safer-at-home policies. Counterarguments—even when morally-laden (e.g., public health ideas related to the preservation of life) had little impact on their convictions. Forsyth attributes these behaviors not only to the illusion of morality, but to other factors of groupthink such as cohesion and isolation, that were extremely prevalent during the COVID-19 pandemic. When the illusion of morality—contributing to groupthink—is applied to cancel culture, it is clear how experiencing heightened conviction for a moral stance, without an openness to critically examine alternative ideas, unites people to take action.

Conclusion

In sum, three group-related social psychological phenomena—social contagion, group polarization, and groupthink—appear to contribute to cancel culture online. If the factors that contribute to cancel culture are identified and understood, it is possible that more reasoned responses—those driven by less emotion and less social influence—may emerge in response to perceived wrongdoing online.

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